MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 1: Paradise Lost Book I and Mac Flecknoe

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Milton builds epic grandeur around a theological conflict, while Dryden turns the machinery of grandeur into a satirical coronation of dullness.

Start with a picture

A great ceremonial platform can honour a hero. Put a ridiculous claimant on the same platform, and the ceremony begins to expose him. These works show both the force of elevated language and the possibilities of turning it against a subject.

1. Paradise Lost: Book I

Milton invokes heavenly inspiration and announces an inquiry into disobedience, loss, and divine justice. The poem begins after the rebel angels' defeat, not at the chronological beginning of creation. This opening within an ongoing story is an epic convention often called **in medias res**.

Satan and Beelzebub awaken in Hell. Satan speaks with impressive defiance, rallies the fallen host, and helps turn defeat into the language of continuing ambition. The devils gather, and Pandemonium is constructed. Book I prepares their assembly; the extended debate over strategy belongs chiefly to Book II.

Read Satan's rhetoric critically

Courage, energy, and resistance can make the speeches attractive. Yet the narrator also frames the setting, suffering, and dependence that the speeches try to overcome. Satan's freedom of movement exists within a larger divine permission he does not control.

A speech can be persuasive without being the poem's final truth. Do not simply identify Satan with Milton or assume that impressive language proves moral superiority.

Epic method and grand style

Blank verse supports long sentences and changes in emphasis. Invocations, catalogues, epic similes, biblical references, and classical allusions give scale. Comparisons can enlarge a figure and simultaneously expose a limitation. The reader must judge how grandeur works, not only admire its sound.

Puritanism and humanism

Christian argument and classical learning interact. The poem’s concern with obedience and freedom does not remove its use of human intellectual ambition, rhetoric, and inherited epic forms. Discuss a tension rather than forcing two traditions into separate boxes.

2. Dryden: Mac Flecknoe

The poem invents a kingdom of nonsense in which Flecknoe selects Shadwell as his successor. A literary rivalry becomes a mock royal succession. The ceremonial language praises the very incapacity it pretends to celebrate.

Mock heroic means the deliberate mismatch of elevated style and a diminished subject. Prophecy, genealogy, public procession, and coronation are adapted to a literary attack. Heroic couplets make antithesis and judgement sharply memorable.

The poem is a satirist’s construction, not an objective psychological assessment of the historical Shadwell. Analyse how the attack is made and which literary values it assumes.

3. Compare the works

Milton uses epic resources to investigate authority on a large moral scale. Dryden uses related resources to expose an alleged failure of artistic authority. Their forms are not identical: blank verse and rhymed couplets produce different kinds of movement and closure.

Quick check

1. Is all the devils’ strategic debate in Book I? **No; Book II develops it.**
2. Does Satan’s impressive speech equal authorial endorsement? **No.**
3. Is the coronation in Dryden a real historical ceremony? **No; it is a satirical fiction.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define elevated style through authority and scale.
2. Discuss Milton’s epic opening and verse.
3. Analyse Satan’s rhetoric against narrative framing.
4. Explain Dryden’s mock coronation.
5. Compare form and the reader’s judgement.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not confuse Book I with Book II or treat a character’s grand speech as proof that the narrator endorses it.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare the uses of elevated style in Paradise Lost Book I and Mac Flecknoe.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Elevated style in the two works depends on a relation between language and the authority it appears to confer. Paradise Lost gives a cosmic conflict the resources of epic, while Mac Flecknoe transfers ceremonial greatness to a deliberately diminished literary claimant. Both require readers to assess what grandeur makes persuasive.

Satan’s rhetoric offers a particularly important test. His energy and defiance can attract sympathy, but the narrative setting exposes pain, defeat, and limited power. A strong reading therefore attends to the distance between a speaker’s self-presentation and the narrator’s framing. The epic simile can enlarge the scene while also introducing a qualifying comparison.

Dryden makes this distance the organising principle of satire. The form of royal succession appears to grant Shadwell legitimacy, but its praise measures his fitness to inherit dullness. Heroic couplets supply balanced and memorable turns that expose the contradiction. The procedure attacks artistic pretension through the language by which prestige is normally granted.

An effective comparison does not say only that one poem is serious and the other funny. It explains how style produces authority, how readers are invited to question it, and how blank verse and couplets sustain different kinds of judgement.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Bring out the heroic qualities of Milton’s Satan from book 1.
2. Explain how Milton’s poetry weds the puritan spirit with that of the renaissance.
3. Describe Milton’s Hell
4. Consider Paradise Lost as an epic.
5. Discuss “Mac Flecknoe” as a mock heroic poem.
6. Consider Dryden as a satirist.
7. Description of Shadwell’s crowning ceremony in “Mac Flecknoe.”
8. Genre of “Mac Flecknoe.”
9. How does the poem “Mac Flecknoe” begin?
10. Advice of Flecknoe to Shadwell after crowning him.